all his holidays, attended summer school and successfully completed all the papers in two semesters in that short phase, saving a whole academic year.

He began enjoying his studies and it reflected in the high grades he earned. He did brilliantly in the design paper and graduated with the highest marks in the subject. As he recalls: ‘I did not do well in engineering. I passed, but I didn’t do well. As soon as I got into architecture, I just came into my own.’ But his academic excellence came at a price: as the teams he led often won the best prize, he was obliged to take his group members to bars where they downed as many pitchers of whisky sours as they could at Ratan’s expense.

Phil Handler was surprised by Ratan’s commitment to studies. Recalling how industrious he was as a student, Handler said that though Ratan was a ‘rich man’s son’, he ‘worked very hard at Cornell’ and added: ‘That’s his nature, working hard.’

In the final year of college, architecture students were required to complete a thesis that would be graded. Ratan’s thesis, which he did in 1961, won him special recognition. He had worked tirelessly on it. Ratan recalls that during the closing weeks of the semester, he would put in ‘thirty-three to forty hours straight’ and then ‘collapse for six hours’, only to get back to work afterwards. He was so consumed by his determination to do well that he rarely stepped out of the project room, even for meals.

The thesis was a futuristic design of his perception of what the Tata Headquarters should look like. It was a ‘marvel’ of a thesis, recalls his classmate James Bower. This fifth-year project was judged to be so exceptional that it was ‘recommended by juries’, comments Carter. He adds that because of Ratan’s serious approach to academics, he secured a place amongst the more accomplished students of the class.

For Ratan, studying architecture was not only exciting, but it also prepared him for his future role—as the leader of the largest conglomerate in India. Talking about how it aided him, he says that in all businesses, you face problems and ‘you have to creatively think of solutions. All the miles of tracing paper that all of us wasted in one concept after another … taught us one thing. We did not stick with one thing. We tried and we tried and we improved and we reconceived what we had to do. It is no different in business.’ Besides the capacity to look at alternative options to resolve business problems, Ratan has also attributed his success in the product area to the capability he developed at Cornell. He says that he was able to